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From the editor-in-chief

Readers who inspire, who are role models, who have charisma and a clear message and who above all hold out hope for the future are a rare breed in the best of times. No wonder that when a new kind of leader took office a month ago in the USA, the world cheered. The tougher the times the greater the need for transformational leadership. India has had truly great leaders since its Independence but as it nears its 15th general election, such leaders have become an endangered species. Since the onset of successive coalition governments since 1996 there has not been a single leader from either of the national parties with a pan-Indian appeal, someone who could galvanise the nation and override caste, religion and regional considerations which have been the bane of Indian politics.

The establishment of coalition governments in India has meant the coming to national prominence of regional leaders and the growing importance of regional parties. Now this is not bad in itself as India needs its states to be well governed as the whole country should be.

But the rise of the states in determining national power equations has also resulted in the shrinking of India's two largest national parties—the Congress and the BJP. Today, these two parties together do not command even 50 per cent of the vote. The Congress's vote share has shrunk from its 1984 high of 49.1 per cent (in what was an unusual election following the assassination of Indira Gandhi), to 26 per cent in the last election, down from an average of over 35 per cent of the vote. The BJP's vote share in the last election was 22.16 per cent.

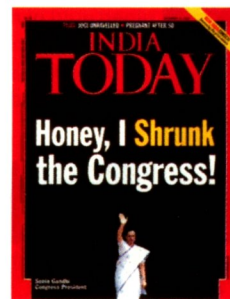
This has led to several detrimental developments: the compulsions of coalition have left the national parties at the mercy of regional allies. Instead of national leaders contributing to the rise of regional strongmen, the situation is completely reversed—the regional satrap is the man who can actually call the shots as to who heads the government in Delhi. India is not being ruled by the Centre, it is actually being dictated to by the periphery.

The response of the national parties has been extremely opportunistic and extremely disappointing. All ideology has become secondary to the pursuit of power. India's governance is therefore at the mercy of divisive caste and regional issues, when what it needs more than ever is a cohesive national agenda.

Our cover story this week is on the decline and fall of national politics and India's leadership vacuum. It has been written by Editor Prabhu Chawla who has tracked changes in the country's government and politics for the last three decades. He says, "When it comes to laying claim to power either for the Congress or the BJP, no price is too high. Conviction has given way to convenience."

For all their pretensions of grandeur, the Congress and the BJP must both know that by refusing to introspect and change, they are no longer masters of their own destiny and have failed themselves. What is worse, they have failed India.

(Aroon Purie)



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